

» FROM THE
WORLD OF FOOTBALL



AP

CHAMPION STUFF

International giants **scored big wins** as Japan clinched another World Cup qualification.



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STORIES

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Club football halted for the international break for the final time this season as the stars took to the field donning their national colours. While some nations sought to progress in their respective Nations League campaigns, others focused on securing qualification for the World Cup next year.

Nations League reaches business end

Defending champion Spain held on to its nerves to edge past the Netherlands in a

penalty shootout and advance to the final four of the UEFA Nations League.

After a high-octane first leg which ended 2-2 in Rotterdam, the reverse fixture matched and improved on the intensity, with the Dutch fighting back three times in the tie.

Mikel Oyarzabal's regulation-time brace and Lamine Yamal's **(above)** spectacular strike in extra time were cancelled out by the Dutch trio of Memphis Depay, Ian Maatsen and Xavi Simons, taking the match to penalties.

In the shootout, Yamal — who earlier became the youngest goalscorer in the tournament's history — was the only Spaniard to miss from the spot, while Noa Lang and Donyell Malen failed to convert for the Oranje, resulting in their exit from the competition.